

A final that showcased India's domestic depth

Vidarbha won its third Ranji Trophy in seven years, defeating Kerala on first-innings lead. Kerala's historic final run ended despite spirited efforts, while Vidarbha's **young stars and depth** shone through.

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Of the 22 players that played the Ranji Trophy final, only one had ever played international cricket. And that was not because the match was clashing with the Champions Trophy.

When the biggest match in domestic cricket is played by two teams that aren't among the most glamorous ones — read Mumbai, Delhi, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu — it tells us there is depth in Indian cricket and that the talent net continues to get wider.

Small-town cricketers are making it big. M.S. Dhoni's descendants continue to grow.

This year's Ranji Trophy final featured Vidarbha and Kerala, once among India's weakest teams. Both have made remarkable progress.

The final at the VCA Stadium in Nagpur proved Kerala had some way to go yet. Sachin Baby's men reaching the final itself is a great feat. It was not just their first-ever

final; after starting to play in the Ranji Trophy in 1957-58, it was the first time they had made it to the knockout stage since 2018-19.

For Vidarbha, this was the fourth final in seven years. After losing the final to Mumbai last year, the victory against Kerala must have tasted particularly sweet for Akshay Wadkar's men, as they lifted the most prestigious trophy in India's domestic cricket on a bright Sunday afternoon early this month.

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The scores



Vidarbha 379 (Danish Malewar 153, Karun Nair 86, M.D. Nidheesh 3-61) and 375 for 9 dec (Karun Nair 135, Danish Malewar 73, Aditya Sarwate 4-96) vs. **Kerala** 342 (Sachin Baby 98, Sarwate 79, Darshan Nalkande 3-52)

Result: Vidarbha won on first-innings lead

They were undoubtedly the best side in the competition, which began in October with teams from across the country battling it out in the league stage. Remarkably, they won six out of their seven league matches and took the first-innings lead in the remaining one; then, they beat Tamil Nadu in the quarterfinal and then Mumbai in the semifinal.

By such a high standard, it might have been a disappointment that they could win the final only by the first-innings lead. So Kerala did well enough not to lose outright to a team that had been playing dominant cricket all through the tournament.

And the fact is Kerala came close to taking that all-important first innings lead. At one stage, with the 36-year-old captain Baby looking determined to play the innings of his life and Jalaj Saxena, who has been a magnificent servant for Kerala cricket after moving out from Madhya Pradesh, giving him adequate company for the seventh wicket, the visiting side seemed quite capable of going past Vidarbha's total of 379.